command post. The first wave of attacking Chinese troops was met with a volley of rifle and LMG fire, causing serious damage.

Realizing that the machine gun crew had failed to follow him, Gurdial continued to make his way up, eventually joining the Charlie Company platoon. Despite serious casualties, the Chinese were now bringing everything to bear on these three positions as the defending troops grimly held on. The second wave was also fought off, but only just, as the Chinese were closing in rapidly. The advantage of the AK-47 in close combat was tremendous as the attackers could flood the area ahead of them with fire. The Chinese were also using LMGs and high explosive fragmentation grenades.

As the third wave was bunching up to launch yet another attack on the depleted positions, the Vickers machine gun crew under the command of Jemadar Mohan Lal ducked past Battalion HQ and made their way past the lower platoon. This platoon was perhaps the best equipped to fight it out as they were the only ones with plenty of ammunition. This was seen by the lower platoon and men started abandoning their posts in ones and twos. The senior JCO, Subedar B. C. Roy, then lost his nerve and, instead of looking to support the platoons grappling with the enemy above him, set off for Bridge 3 with the bulk of the surviving men.

Unaware of the hurried exit of the lower platoon from the battlefield, Rikh and the remnants braced themselves for the third wave. Ammunition was all but spent and the men were exhausted, finding it almost impossible to effectively throw grenades uphill. The third assault was two-pronged—from the south and southwest. As the Chinese closed in, Gurdial Singh led out the last remaining men in a counter attack, but the show of defiance was only a desperate symbolic gesture. Gurdial was overpowered and the two platoons were wiped out almost to the man.

Amazingly, the command post with the three officers in it was still holding out. In Rikh’s own words: ‘Captain Bhatia and I continued to engage the enemy from the doorway of the bunker. When I heard that the firing had stopped from the locality on my left, I came out of the bunker to see what had happened. As I stepped out of the bunker, a Chinese soldier who had crawled up to the side of the bunker threw a grenade at me. This grenade hit my rifle and exploded. My left jaw was broken and my lip cut open. I fell down. Lieutenant Bhup Singh rushed out of the bunker, shot the enemy soldier and pulled me back into the bunker. I got up with the support